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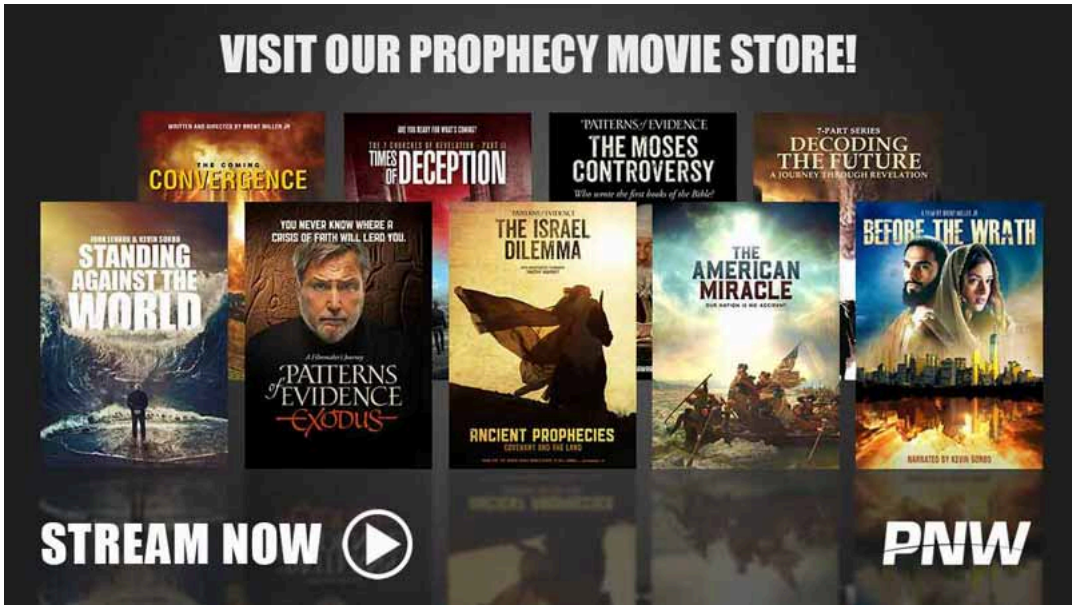

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ARTICLE

The Gospel According To Talarico: Progressive Christianity Reshaping Politics

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BY PNW STAFF MARCH 06, 2026

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The political rise of James Talarico took a dramatic turn this week when the Texas Democrat defeated Jasmine Crockett in the Democratic primary for the U.S. Senate. The victory, with Talarico capturing roughly 52.8% of the vote, stunned many observers and instantly elevated the 36-year-old state lawmaker to national prominence as the Democratic nominee in one of the most closely watched Senate races of 2026.

But as Talarico celebrates his political breakthrough, a different conversation is unfolding among many Christians in Texas and across the country. The issue is not simply his politics. It is the theology he promotes.

Talarico has built much of his political brand around Christianity. He frequently speaks about faith, preaches in churches, and presents his progressive agenda as rooted in the teachings of Jesus. Yet critics argue that the version of Christianity he presents bears little resemblance to historic Christian doctrine and instead reflects a modern movement often described as "progressive Christianity."

For many believers, the concern is simple: when politicians reshape the teachings of Christ to fit contemporary ideology, the result can be a faith that sounds biblical but ultimately departs from Scripture.

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For some observers, Talarico's rise feels strikingly familiar.

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expression of Christianity itself.

In speeches and interviews, he argues that faith demands support for progressive causes. But critics say that approach doesn't simply apply Christian principles to politics. Instead, it reinterprets Christianity through the lens of modern ideology.

"God Is Nonbinary"

One of Talarico's most controversial statements came when he declared:

"God is nonbinary."

The comment drew immediate backlash from many Christians who saw it as an attempt to align theology with contemporary gender ideology.

Christian doctrine has long taught that God transcends human biology, but critics argue that Talarico's statement was clearly framed to support modern gender identity debates rather than classical theology.

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Jesus as a "Radical Feminist"

Talarico has also described Jesus as a "radical feminist," suggesting that Christ's teachings were primarily about dismantling patriarchal systems.

While the Gospels clearly show Jesus honoring women in ways that were culturally radical for the first century, critics argue that labeling Him with modern political categories risks distorting His mission.

For historic Christianity, the central message of Jesus was redemption from sin and reconciliation with God -- not the advancement of a political ideology.

Using the Gospel of Thomas

Perhaps the most controversial moment came when Talarico cited the ancient Gospel of Thomas to support claims about gender and theology.

The text is widely considered a second-century Gnostic writing that was rejected by the early church and excluded from the New Testament. Scholars regard it as outside orthodox Christian teaching.

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Abortion and the Story of Mary

Talarico has also argued that the Bible supports abortion rights.

In one widely circulated explanation, he suggested that the story of the angel Gabriel announcing Jesus' birth shows that God sought Mary's consent before the conception of Christ -- implying that the biblical narrative affirms the concept of reproductive choice.

Many Christian scholars strongly dispute that interpretation, arguing that the Annunciation story was never intended to support modern debates about abortion.

"Atheists More Christ-Like"

Another statement that generated backlash came when Talarico said he has met atheists and followers of other religions who were "more Christ-like than" some Christians in the Texas legislature.

The remark was meant as a critique of political hypocrisy. But critics argue that it reflects a broader trend in progressive theology: redefining Christianity primarily as moral behavior rather than faith in Christ.

A Larger Battle for the Soul of the Church

The debate surrounding James Talarico ultimately points to a larger conflict unfolding inside American Christianity.

Should the church adapt its theology to align with modern social movements?

Or should it remain rooted in the historic teachings of Scripture?

For many believers, the concern is not about partisan politics. It is about theological integrity.

Texas has long been part of the Bible Belt -- a region where faith still shapes culture and public life. Talarico's victory shows that a new form of religious messaging is emerging within American politics: one that blends progressive ideology with Christian language.

Whether voters ultimately embrace that message in the general election remains to be seen.

But one thing is already clear.

The debate over James Talarico is not just about a Senate race.

It is about what Christianity itself means in America today.

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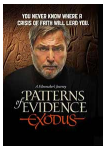

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